ETON Advanced French Grammar: Specialists

EW 16

92 THE SUBJUNCTIVE (2)

You have seen that the subjunctive is used after certain conjunctions; it is also used after certain verbs. But, if the subject of that verb is the same as the subject of the verb that follows it, you should NOT use the subjunctive; an infinitive construction will be used in its

place. If, for now, you accept that expressions of emotion may take the subjunctive the following examples should make this clear:

I am glad (sad) that I am here *Je suis content (triste) d'être ici*
- no change of subject, therefore use an infinitive

I am glad (sad) that he is here *Je suis content (triste) qu'il soit ici*
- change of subject, therefore the subjunctive must be used

See also the third section of p42 [90], where the subjunctive is avoided by using a conjunction followed by the infinitive:

We had lunch before we went out *Nous avons déjeuné avant de sortir*
- no change of subject either side of the conjunction (before)

In certain cases the subjunctive can be avoided by using a noun instead of a verb. Note the following examples:

Before he left/leaves . . .	*Avant son départ . . .*
Before he arrived/arrives . . .	*Avant son arrivée . . .*
Before he died/dies . . .	*Avant sa mort . . .*

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93. The subjunctive must be used after the following when there is a change of subject, but remember that an infinitive should be used if there is no change of subject:

a) After verbs of wishing, command and preference

to want	**vouloir que / désirer que**
it is necessary that (must - see example)	**il faut que / il est nécessaire que**
to order that	**ordonner que**
to prefer that	**préférer que / aimer mieux que**

I want him to come	*Je veux qu'il vienne*
They prefer us to stay there	*Ils préfèrent que nous y restions*
The teacher ordered that we be quiet	*Le professeur a ordonné que nous nous taisions*
She must do the shopping tonight (ie It is necessary that . . .)	*Il faut qu'elle fasse les courses ce soir*

BUT

I want to come (no change of subject)	*Je veux venir* (use an infinitive)
We prefer to eat chocolate	*Nous préférons manger du chocolat*

b) After verbs and expressions of emotion

To be glad that	**être content(e) que**

You should also complete the pre-test exercises as part of your EW

To be sad that	**être triste que**
To be sorry that	**regretter que / être désolé(e) que**
To be annoyed / angry that	**être fâché(e) que**
To be ashamed that	**avoir honte que**

We were ashamed that they said it	*Nous avons eu honte qu'ils l'aient dit*
She is glad that you are coming	*Elle est contente que vous veniez*
She's glad she's coming (no change of subject)	*Elle est contente de venir* (use an infinitive)

c) **Expressions of fear**

These are really verbs of emotion but, unlike the above, they must have *ne* placed before the verb in the subjunctive:

avoir peur que + NE **craindre que + NE**

I am afraid my mother may hear me	*j'ai peur que ma mère ne m'entende*

NOTE

i) compare this with *de peur* (OR *de crainte*) *que + NE* : for fear that/lest,

For fear that she might see us	*de crainte qu'elle ne nous voie*

ii) In the examples above, note that the English "may", "might" and also "should" convey the subjunctive in English and need not be translated with any form of **pouvoir** or **devoir** in French.

d) **After verbs and expressions of doubt or denial**

to deny that	**nier que**
to doubt if/whether	**douter que** (nb NEVER *douter si*)
I doubted if he was telling the truth	*J'ai douté qu'il dise la vérité*
I doubt whether she will read it	*Je doute qu'elle le lise*

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94. **The subjunctive is used after most impersonal structures (examples given below) EXCEPT those conveying CERTAINTY or PROBABILITY or CLARITY**

Hence the subjunctive is used after:

It is necessary that	**il est nécessaire que / il faut que**
It is possible/ impossible that	**il est possible / impossible que**
It is unlikely that	**il est peu probable que**
It is doubtful if/whether	**il est douteux QUE** (nb NEVER *douteux si*)
It is uncertain whether	**il n'est pas sûr/certain que**
It may be / is possible that	**il se peut que**
It is (high) time that	**il est (grand) temps que**

It is necessary that you leave immediately	*il faut que tu t'en ailles tout de suite*
It is possible that she will come today	*il se peut qu'elle vienne aujourd'hui*

But the subjunctive is not used after:

It is certain that	**il est certain que**
It is probable / likely that	**il est probable que**
It is obvious / clear / evident that	**il est clair / évident que**
It is certain that he has forgotten	**il est certain qu'il a oublié**
It is likely that he will come tomorrow	**il est probable qu'il viendra demain**

NOTE

-	It seems that	**il semble que + SUBJUNCTIVE**
	It appears that	**il paraît que + INDICATIVE**
	It seems he is right	*il semble qu'il ait raison*
	It appears he is right	*il paraît qu'il a raison*
-	It seems to me/ you/ him etc that	**il me / te/ lui semble que + INDICATIVE**
	It seemed to them that she was wrong	*il leur a semblé qu'elle avait tort*

95 . The subjunctive will be used after a superlative (not a comparative):

She is the prettiest girl I know	*C'est la plus jolie fille que je connaisse*
It is the biggest town I have visited	*C'est la plus grande ville que j'aie visitée*

REMEMBER : AVOID the subjunctive in the following cases:

1. when both parts of the sentence have the same subject

I'm afraid I might lose it	*j'ai peur de le perdre*

2. when you can use a noun instead

until he died	*jusqu'à sa mort*
before he was born	*avant sa naissance*

3. the subjunctive is NEVER used after:

après que **dès que (aussitôt que)** **chaque fois que**

After she had left		*Après qu'elle était partie*
	or	*Après son départ* (see 2 above)
As soon as she had returned		*Dès qu'elle était revenue*
	or	*Dès son retour* (see 2 above)
Whenever she went to bed		*Chaque fois qu'elle se couchait*

4. espérer que

I hope he will pass his exam	*J'espère qu'il réussira à son examen*